hypothesis is offered by Raymond Garthoff, who first revealed the early warning procedure in 1987.[21] Garthoff remains one of the best-informed and most meticulous experts on the missile crisis, and he explained that the source of his information was a CIA clandestine officer who mistakenly believed that Penkovsky's message did not reach the higher reaches of the agency. The account was also mistaken in stating that the phone calls came on 22 October rather than 2 November.

Penkovsky's official cover was as a civilian official of the State Committee for the Co-ordination of Scientific Research Work. This allowed him trips to Britain and France, where he was secretly debriefed by his case officers (the meetings were recorded, transcribed, and later declassified by the CIA). At their first meeting in London in April 1961, Penkovsky tried to persuade his handlers to furnish him with atomic demolition munitions to place at strategic points around Moscow, so that at the anointed moment he could 'decapitate' the Soviet state.[22] This might have just been to impress his case officers with his commitment to the cause (he also wanted to wear the uniforms of a colonel in both the British and US armies). It nevertheless resonates with Garthoff's idea that Penkovsky could have deliberately tried to provoke a nuclear attack on the Soviet Union: 'So when he was about to go down, he evidently decided to play Samson and bring the temple down on everyone else as well.'[23] This would presumably have meant providing the KGB with the DISTANT procedures without explaining their purpose. Based on a KGB report of his interrogation, Fursenko and Naftali state that the day after his arrest, Penkovsky undertook to cooperate with KGB.[24] This included providing details of his meetings with SIS and CIA contacts and an offer to help in a sting operation against them. Whether that was part of a plan to 'bring down the temple' is unknowable. What happened in KGB headquarters in the Lubyanka between 22 October and 2 November is a puzzle, but one that may well remain a mystery.

Their man in Havana